

metrics

➤ **\$92.6875**

Microsoft's stock price

Bill Gates' wealth

➤ **\$105 billion**

In your face, dude!

Shoppers may soon be assaulted with the digital equivalent of mid-air blimps, thanks to a Hungarian-US firm that plans to manufacture a new type of projection device. An appliance the size of a vending machine will project still or moving images about 16 inches in size, which the human eye will perceive as floating in mid-air. The two-dimensional, high-



definition colour images can be seen only at certain angles in front of the projection device.

The long-term plan is to have many of these terminals installed and managed by central servers and with thousands of such terminals installed it could bring in a lot of marketing dollars. The terminals will be installed in shopping centres and will sell airtime rather than the appliances themselves.

Mitnick warns fellow hackers against 'Scapegoat sweepstakes'

The world's most notorious hacker says the US government should focus on securing its computer systems rather than snooping on citizens. Kevin Mitnick stresses that hackers should take extreme care given the sensitive political environment and the new laws defining hacks as acts of terrorism. He also warned that any hacker could win the 'scapegoat sweepstakes' at any time, receiving a harsh sentence to serve as an example to other hackers.

Mitnick firmly believes the newly proposed Patriot Act is just an excuse for law enforcement to further its own agenda.

Mitnick calls the Patriot Act ludicrous, saying, "Terrorists have proved that they are interested in total genocide, not subtle little hacks of the US infrastructure. Yet the government wants a blank search warrant to spy and snoop on everyone's communications. The government does things like insisting that all encryption programs should have a backdoor. But surely no one is stupid enough to think the terrorists are going to use encryption systems with a backdoor. The terrorists will simply hire a programmer to come up with a secure encryption scheme."

Who is?

Carleton S. (Carly) Fiorina

▲ *Who is she?*

One of the few women to hold a top post in the tech industry—or in corporate America, *The Sunday Times* called her "the most successful American woman of the decade".

▲ *Why is she in the news?*

A while ago industry experts were speculating whether Fiorina would be dismissed as chief executive of Hewlett-Packard. In an apparent vote of confidence, less than two weeks after the announcement of the acquisition of Compaq, Fiorina was elected to H-P's board of directors. Now she is handling the second-largest computer company after IBM.

▲ *What's her new role now?*

Her task now is to follow through with the Compaq takeover. The key would be if the merger exploits cost-savings and service enhancements at the \$87 billion merged company.

tomorrow technology

Biometric ATMs

The analysis of certain unique body 'signatures', such as fingerprints and retina scanning—known as biometric technology—could soon be put to use in ATMs for security purposes. The idea has for long been considered a viable option to personal identification numbers (PINs). Such ATMs, powered by BioID, could soon be providing service to Australian bank customers, with a promise of

reducing personal identification overheads drastically.

BioID is a relatively cheaper option as compared to hardware-dependent biometrics requiring expensive hardware, as it just involves installing a regular Web camera and microphone. BioID 3.0 uses face, voice and lip-movement recognition for identification and authorisation.

The technology only

requires the user's cooperation while being recognised and doesn't need him to give away any information. In comparison, fingerprint scanning means a user's fingerprints can be used and recognised without him actually being present.

There are already quite a few installations of biometric-enabled ATMs in the US and Europe that use fingerprint and iris recognition.

◆ B2B to reach \$4.3 trillion ◆ Qualcomm ships its first Bluetooth-ready chipset ◆ Microsoft phases out Windows NT 4.0 ◆